

CHILLISOURCE GAME ENGINE PARTICLE STUDY

By

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ChilliSource Game Engine Particle Study

Chairperson: Travis Wheeler

This is the short summary of why this thesis is awesome and *YOU* really want to read it!

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

Thanks guys ...

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CHAPTER 1 INTRODUCTION

1.1 Thesis Organization

The rest of this thesis is organized as follows:

- **Chapter 2** Review of particle systems and the ChilliSource game engine
- **Chapter 3** Overview of the automated pong game that was created to facilitate case studies
- **Chapter 4** Overview of the systems used to instrument the ChilliSource engine
- **Chapter 5** Discussion of the two case studies performed to explore contention in large data structures
- **Chapter 6** Discussion of three interesting aspects of the ChilliSource particle effect component

CHAPTER 2 BACKGROUND

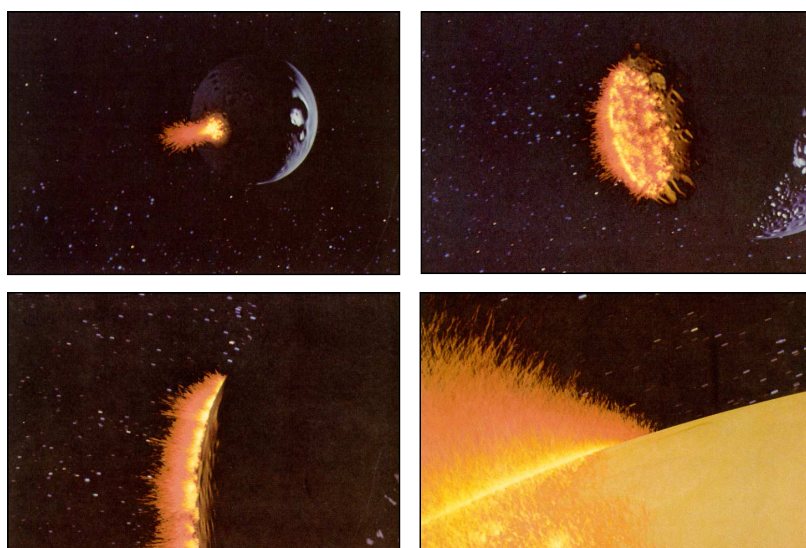


Figure 2.1: The particle effect created by William T. Reeves from the film *Star Trek II: The Wrath of Khan*

2.1 Particle Systems

2.1.1 Overview

Visual representation of "fuzzy objects", or objects that do not have well-defined surfaces, in computer graphics is generally considered a difficult task due to the non-deterministic changes in the fuzzy object's shape and form. When working on the film *Star Trek II: The Wrath of Khan*, a researcher at Lucasfilm Ltd., William T. Reeves, developed what he called a **particle system**, which is "... a collection of many minute particles that together represent a fuzzy object. Over a period of time, particles are generated into a system, move

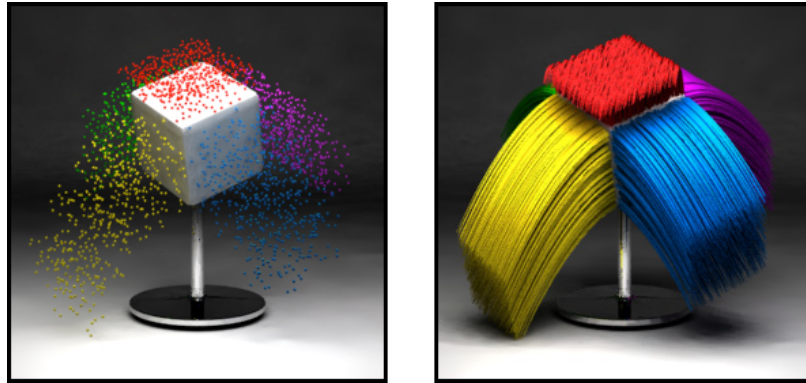


Figure 2.2: Left: A cube emitting a stream of 1000 animated particles from 5 of its 6 faces. Right: A cube emitting a stream of 1000 static particles, or strands, from 5 of its 6 faces

and change from within the system, and die from the system.” [1] Although the concept of modeling these objects as a collection of particles was not novel, Reeves' basic framework for particle systems is still widely used today to create complex visual effects in video games and films.

Fuzzy objects like sparks, clouds, stars, water, and crowds of people can be easily translated and modeled as a particle system, but particle systems can also be used to model objects that contain numerous strands like hair and grass. These objects can be represented by rendering every strand as the entire lifetime of a particle in the system and is then treated as a single strand. The particles in a system that have a distributed lifetime (e.g. sparks) are thought of as *animated* and particles that are rendered all at once (e.g. hair) are thought of as *static*. For the duration of our own study, we have exclusively focused on animated particles.

2.1.2 Particle Model

2.1.2.1 Life Cycle

A particle system has 4 main events that defines its life cycle:

1. Emission (or Generation, according to Reeves)

2. Update
3. Render
4. Death (or Extinction, according to Reeves)

The **Emission** event is the initial process in which particles are generated with their initial values. Often a "generation shape"[1] is used during the emission phase that defines the two or three dimensional space that the particles can originate, or emit, from. Emission can be increased or decreased in frequency using the *emission rate*, and the number of particles that enter the particle system each emission can also be changed using the *particles per emission* variable. After emission, particles in the particle system undergo the **Update** and **Render** events. These events are repeated in perpetuum until the particle dies, or undergoes the **Extinction** phase. The **Update** phase involves iterating over all particles throughout the system and updating their attributes (e.g. position, velocity, etc.). The **Render** phase, on the other hand, is the phase in which all of the particles are actually drawn to the screen.

2.1.2.2 Particle Attributes

As mentioned above, each individual particle in a particle system will have attributes that change over time. Although every particle system is different, the following is what Reeves considered to be the core attributes of a particle:

- Position
- Velocity
- Size
- Color
- Transparency
- Shape
- Lifetime

A particle has a position in two or three dimensional space, and its initial position is determined by the emission process. Other attributes that may also change over time

include its speed, direction, size, color, and transparency. Its lifetime, however, is pre-determined at emission, and it is the attribute that dictates how long the particle "lives", or remains on the screen. In order to decrease uniformity and increase realism, all of these values can vary across the particles in the system. For example, the particles in a given particle system could have a varying lifetime of 5 to 10 seconds so that the particles that shared an emission would not all die simultaneously.

2.1.2.3 Hierarchy

It is often convenient to design a particle system such that it is made up of a hierarchy of child particle systems. This hierarchy "can be used to exert global control on a complicated fuzzy object that is composed of many particle systems." [1] In other words, a fuzzy object could easily be transformed in overall shape, size, color, etc. by sweeping through the descendant particle systems. It also allows the grouping together of particle systems that have different types of particles. For example, a campfire fuzzy object would need smoke, sparks, and the flame itself. All of these components would have distinct particle definitions and would be separate particle systems. A particle system hierarchy, in this case, would allow the smoke, sparks, and flame particle systems to be bundled together as a single fuzzy object.

2.2 The ChilliSource Game Engine

2.2.1 Overview

Chosen for its open source and well-thought out architecture, ChilliSource is the game engine that was used in our study of particle systems. ChilliSource is a free, open source game engine created by ChilliWorks which is a group that is part of United Kingdom's Tag Games. It allows developers to create 2D and 3D content for iOS, Android, Kindle, and Windows operating systems in C++ 11. Some of its key features include networking, shader support, responsive (i.e. adaptive to different resolutions) graphical user interfaces, modular

and extensible lighting and shadows, skinned animation, Facebook connect integration, consistent API, and automatic builds of iOS/Android/Kindle applications. [2]

2.2.2 Architecture

The structure of a ChilliSource application is primarily composition based in that it relies on a hierarchy of modules to define its functionality. The main types of modules that comprise the application are *States*, *Systems*, *Entities* and *Components*. Figure 2.3 demonstrates the architecture of a ChilliSource application using these basic modules.

The *Application* instance initializes and manages *Application Systems*, which are modules that describe functionality used across the entire application. A non-exhaustive list of some application systems include the *Task Manager*, *Texture Provider*, *Render System*, and the *State Manager*. The *State Manager*, as shown in Figure 2.3, manages a stack of *States* and ensures that the state on top of the stack is active.

States can be thought of as different parts of the application such as a main menu, inventory, settings menu, pause screen, and the game scene itself. *States*, like the *Application*, initialize and manage *State Systems*. *State Systems* are similar to *Application Systems* except they describe functionality that only pertains to a single state and its lifetime is limited to that state. An important state system, the *Scene*, manage *Entities* that form that scene. The base *State* also creates and manages the *Canvas*, *Gesture*, and "User" state systems. The *Canvas* renders the user interface, the *Gesture* state system helps receive input events like pinching or tapping, and "User" state systems are custom modules built by the developer to describe functionality for the state.

Entities are essentially objects within the game that are defined by both (a) a transform describing their rotation, size, and position and (b) *Components*, which are modules that describe the entity's functionality. *Entities* can also contain a hierarchy of entities in which, much like in particle systems, their transforms and life cycle events are linked by the hierarchy. Some examples of *Components* are AI Controllers, Health, Damage, and Physics.

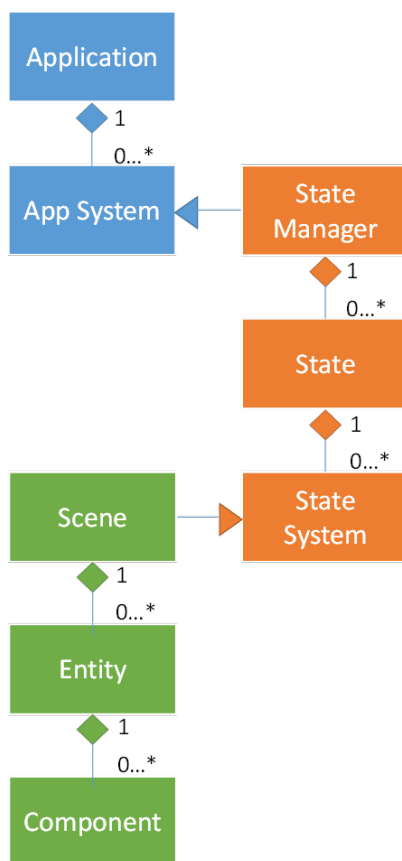


Figure 2.3: The basic structure of a ChilliSource application

ChilliSource’s architecture favors composition over inheritance. For example, if we wanted to create enemy and player *Entities*, we may be tempted to create a base Human *Entity* class that had health related methods and attributes. In order to truly adhere to the spirit of ChilliSource’s design, however, we would create a *Component* called something like **HealthComponent** that could be attached to any single *Entity*. In this way, ChilliSource lends itself to a great deal of code reusability and flexibility.

2.2.3 Life Cycle

The majority of game engines follow a life cycle very similar to the one for particle systems that Reeves developed, which is:

1. Initialize
2. Update
3. Draw
4. Stop

The **Initialize** step usually involves loading textures, sounds, and anything else that the engine needs to do before starting the main game loop. The **Update** step is the heart of game, and is usually driven by some kind of state machine. Some examples of typical states include Menu, Game, Settings, and Exit. The **Draw** step is also part of the main game loop and, just as it sounds, this is where everything is drawn to the screen. Typically, there is some kind of renderer that handles all of the low-level calls to the graphics card (e.g. OpenGL, DirectX, etc.). And, optionally, there is the **Stop** step in which the game has been stopped and all assets and resources will be released. This may or may not be included as a separate state in the **Update** phase, but it is good to logically separate the two events.

ChilliSource, as you may expect, adheres to the basic "Initialize, Update, Draw, and Stop" phases. However, there are a great deal of other events that are perpetuated from the *Application* instance. The following is a list of the main life cycle events that all modules receive:

1. Init
 - This initializes the application and begins the **Update** event.
2. Update
 - This updates the application, its systems, and the state manager's states.
3. Render
 - This renders objects and user interface elements to the screen and is the main draw loop of the application.
4. Suspend

- This will notify active state(s) to pause and it will suspend all systems in reverse order.
5. Resume
 - This resumes the application from a suspended state.
 6. Background
 - This occurs when the application is not in view any longer.
 7. Foreground
 - This occurs when the application is in view again.
 8. Destroy
 - This cleans up the application and releases all systems in reverse order.

All of these events are kicked off from the *Application* instance. The flow of events looks something like *Application* → *Application Systems (State Manager)* → *States* → *State Systems (Scene)* → *Entities* → *Components*. Figure 2.4 shows what this flow looks like for the **Update** life cycle event using pseudocode. Note, however, that each event means something slightly different depending on which module it is called in (e.g. **Update**

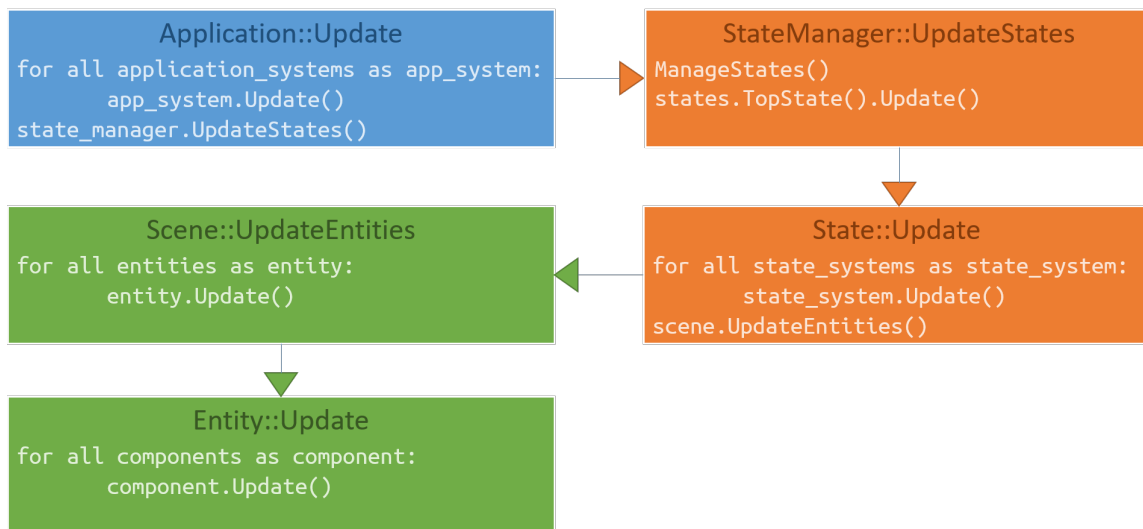


Figure 2.4: An example of the **Update** life cycle event being perpetuated from the *Application* all the way down to a *Component*

in the *Application* means something different than the **Update** in a *State*). Additionally, there are a number of other events that are not discussed here that only have meaning for specific modules (e.g. **OnAddedToEntity** for the *Component* module). See [3] for more information.

Although these are the main events that are automatically pushed by the application, the game developer can create custom events that can be subscribed to by entities, components, and systems. An *Event* can open, close, and notify *Connections*, where a *Connection* allows its user to listen for *Events*. Some examples of custom events are entity collisions, player death, cut scene trigger, game lost, game won, etc.

2.3 ChilliSource Particle Effect Components

2.3.1 Overview

A special type of component in ChilliSource is the *Particle Effect Component*. It inherits from the *Render Component* class¹, which is, just as it sounds, a component that is rendered to the screen. *Render Components* have methods for visibility, culling, casting shadows, and usage of its transformation matrix and sort predicates. They also have virtual methods that child classes can define for materials, transparency, rendering, and bounding boxes. For the purpose of our study, however, the exact details of how a *Render Component* works is outside of our scope. It is only necessary to know that the *Particle Effect Component* is not only updated by its parent entity but is also rendered by the *Application*'s renderer.

¹It's important to note here that the version of ChilliSource that we are using is 1.6.0 and, at the time of writing this paper, it is currently at version 2.0.0. In version 2.0.0, the rendering system is completely overhauled and *Particle Effect Components* are *Volume Components* and not *Render Components*. This new system was not studied and will not be discussed in depth here.

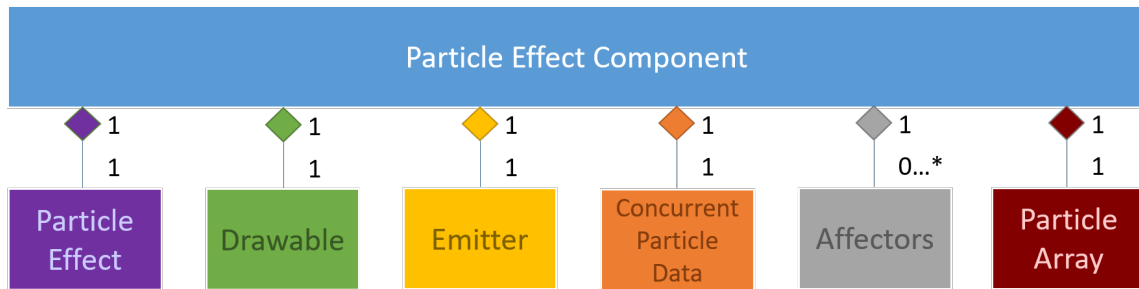


Figure 2.5: The basic structure of a ChilliSource Particle Effect Component

2.3.2 Architecture

2.3.2.1 Overview

The structure of a *Particle Effect Component* in ChilliSource is fairly complex. Its composition includes a number of objects, primitives, and data structures, but we can boil it down to 6 parts:

- A *Particle Effect* object
- A *Particle Drawable* object
- An *Particle Emitter* object
- A list of *Particle Affectors* (optional)
- A *Concurrent Particle Data* object
- An array of *Particle* structs

2.3.2.2 Particle Effect

The *Particle Effect* object contains all of the *Properties* and *Definitions* for the effect. A *Property* defines a value that may be more complex than just a single value. For example, a *Property* could be defined as a random value selected within a certain range, it may be a value that changes over the lifetime of the particle effect, or it could simply be a constant primitive value. *Definitions*, on the other hand, describe a number of properties that should be used to create an object. The *Properties* and *Definitions* that the *Particle Effect* contains

include:

- The particle effect's duration
- The total maximum number of particles used in the effect
- The space in which the particle effect is simulated (either "local" or "world")
- The lifetime property of a new particle generated in the effect
- The initial scale property of a new particle generated in the effect
- The initial rotation property of a new particle generated in the effect
- The initial color property of a new particle generated in the effect
- The initial speed property of a new particle generated in the effect
- The initial angular velocity property of a new particle generated in the effect
- The particle effect's drawable definition
- The particle effect's emitter definition
- The particle effect's affector definitions

These *Properties* and *Definitions* are used to create instances and values that will be used by the *Particle Effect Component*. Thus, the contents of the *Particle Effect* instance completely determines the behavior and appearance of the *Particle Effect Component*. In order to create these intricate *Particle Effects*, we must utilize a JSON particle definition file like the one shown in Code Listing 1. Given the length and verbosity of this file, it is easy to see that defining a particle effect by hand in C++ would quickly become messy and difficult to maintain.

Code Listing 1: An example ChilliSource particle definition file for a generic particle effect. Note how the initial and changing-over-time (i.e. "affector") *Properties* can either be random values or constants.

```

1  {
2      "Duration": "1.0",
3      "MaxParticles": "10000",
4      "SimulationSpace": "World",
5      "LifetimeProperty": {
6          "Type": "RandomConstant",
7          "LowerValue": "0.8",

```

```

8     "UpperValue": "1.2"
9 },
10 "InitialScaleProperty": {
11     "Type": "RandomConstant",
12     "LowerValue": "0.5 0.5",
13     "UpperValue": "1.2 1.2"
14 },
15 "InitialRotationProperty": "0.0",
16 "InitialColourProperty": "0.0 0.0 0.0 0.0",
17 "InitialSpeedProperty": "0.5",
18 "InitialAngularVelocityProperty": "0.0",
19 "Drawable": {
20     "Type": "StaticBillboard",
21     "MaterialPath": "Particle/Particle.csmaterial",
22     "AtlasPath": "TextureAtlases/Particle/Particle.csatlas",
23     "ImageIds": "Generic",
24     "Size": "1.0 1.0",
25     "SizePolicy": "FitMaintainingAspect"
26 },
27 "Emitter": {
28     "Type": "Cone",
29     "EmissionMode": "Stream",
30     "EmitFromType": "Inside",
31     "EmitDirectionType": "AwayFromBase",
32     "EmissionRateProperty": "100.0f",
33     "ParticlesPerEmissionProperty": "10000",
34     "EmissionChanceProperty": "1.0",
35     "RadiusProperty": "0.5",
36     "AngleProperty": "0.8"
37 }
38 "Affectors": [
39     {
40         "Type": "ColourOverLifetime",
41         "TargetColourProperty": "0.0 0.0 0.0 0.0",
42         "IntermediateColours": [
43             {
44                 "ColourProperty": {
45                     "Type": "RandomConstant",
46                     "LowerValue": "0.9 0.4 0.12 0.0",
47                     "UpperValue": "1.0 0.25 0.0 0.5"
48                 },
49                 "TimeProperty": "0.15"
50             },
51             {
52                 "ColourProperty": {
53                     "Type": "RandomConstant",
54                     "LowerValue": "0.9 0.4 0.12 0.0",
55                     "UpperValue": "1.0 0.25 0.0 0.5"
56                 },
57                 "TimeProperty": "0.75"
58             }
59         ]
60     },
61     {
62         "Type": "ScaleOverLifetime",

```

```

63     "ScaleProperty": {
64         "Type": "RandomConstant",
65         "LowerValue": "0.75 1.5",
66         "UpperValue": "1.0 2.0"
67     }
68 }
69 ]
70 }

```

2.3.2.3 Particle Drawable

The *Drawable* object is responsible for rendering all of the particles that belong to its *Particle Effect Component*. A *Static Billboard Particle Drawable*², which is a *Drawable* that renders each and every individual particle as camera facing sprites, is used to accomplish this. The *Drawable* will always render particles on the main game thread.

2.3.2.4 Particle Emitter

The *Emitter* object is used to spawn new particles during **Emission**. The *Emitter* gets to decide the direction, location, and moment that a new particle emits. Unlike the rendering that a *Drawable* does, the *Emitter* emits particles as a background task. There are 5 different kinds of *Emitters*, and their differences lie in the "generation", or emission, shape:

- *Point Particle Emitter*
 - This emitter spawns particles at the parent entity's position with a random direction.
- *Circle Particle Emitter*
 - This emitter spawns particles either within a circle or on the circle's perimeter. It can be set to emit particles with a random direction or a direction away from the center of the circle.

²As of version 1.6.0, the only *Drawable* type available to us is the *Static Billboard*, but the current architecture suggests that there could be different types of *Drawables* in future versions.

- *Sphere Particle Emitter*
 - Similar to the *Circle Particle Emitter*, this emitter spawns particles either within a sphere or on the sphere’s surface. It can be set to emit particles with a random direction or a direction away from the center of the sphere.
- *Cone Particle Emitter*
 - This emitter spawns particles either within a cone or on the cone’s surface. It can be set to emit particles with a random direction or a direction away from the base of the cone.
- *Cone 2D Particle Emitter*
 - This emitter spawns particles either within a 2D cone, on the 2D cone’s edges, or at the 2D cone’s base. It can be set to emit particles with a random direction or a direction away from the base of the 2D cone.

2.3.2.5 Particle Affector

A *Particle Affector* object applies an effect to all particles that change over time. A *Particle Effect Component* can utilize zero or more *Affectors*, and, like the *Emitter*, *Affectors* update particles in a background thread. There are 4 different kinds of *Affectors* that can be applied:

- *Scale Over Lifetime Particle Affector*
 - This affector changes the size of the particles over their lifetime by using a calculated scale factor. This factor will be used to help interpolate the particle’s size across updates.
- *Color Over Lifetime Particle Affector*
 - This affector changes the color of particles over their lifetime by using its initial and target colors to generate interpolated colors across updates.
- *Acceleration Lifetime Particle Affector*
 - This affector changes the speed of particles over their lifetime.

- *Angular Acceleration Lifetime Particle Affector*
 - This affector changes the angular velocity of particles over their lifetime.

2.3.2.6 Particle Array

The *Particle Array* is a data structure that holds all of the particles that comprise the *Particle Effect Component*, and it is used by the *Drawable*, *Emitter*, *Affector*, and *Concurrent Particle Data* instances. Each particle is represented by a *Particle* struct, as shown in Code Listing 2. We can observe that the information provided by this struct mirrors the particle attributes that Reeves used in his particle systems.

Code Listing 2: The struct that is used to describe the properties of a particle within the *Particle Array* in *Particle Effect Component*.

```

1  struct Particle final
2  {
3      bool m_isActive = false;
4      f32 m_lifetime = 0.0f;
5      f32 m_energy = 0.0f;
6      Vector3 m_position;
7      Vector2 m_scale = Vector2::k_one;
8      f32 m_rotation = 0.0f;
9      Colour m_colour = Colour::k_white;
10     Vector3 m_velocity;
11     f32 m_angularVelocity = 0.0f;
12 };

```

2.3.2.7 Concurrent Particle Data

The *Concurrent Particle Data* object is a container for data that is shared by the background and main threads. *Concurrent Particle Data* is written to by the same background thread that emits and affects particles, and it is read by the *Particle Effect Component's Drawable* in the main thread. It contains, essentially, copies of important attributes that are shared by these threads. This includes an array of particles, indices of particles that were just emitted, and the bounds of the particle effect. Thus, all thread synchronization

and locking occurs in *Concurrent Particle Data* and not in the *Particle Effect Component* itself.

It is important to note that *Concurrent Particle Data*'s array of particles uses a different struct than the one used in *Particle Effect Component*. As we can see in Code Listing 3, the struct contains a subset of the information that is provided by *Particle Effect Component*'s *Particle* struct. This is intentional, as we only want to copy the information that will be used by the *Drawable* later.

Code Listing 3: The struct that is used to describe the properties of a particle within the *Particle Array* in *Concurrent Particle Data*.

```

1  struct Particle final
2  {
3      bool m_isActive = false;
4      Vector3 m_position;
5      Vector2 m_scale = Vector2::k_zero;
6      f32 m_rotation = 0.0f;
7      Colour m_colour = Colour::k_white;
8  };

```

2.3.2.8 Other Important Attributes

There are a number of other important attributes that are not the 6 parts discussed above. These include:

- Bounding Box Objects
- Playback Enumerators and Floats
- Custom Events

The *Bounding Box Objects* are containers that describe the effect's shape and are used to aide in the rendering of the effect. The *Playback Enumerators*, *Playback Type* and *Playback State*, help describe the whether or not the particle effect loops and the current life cycle phase of the particle effect, respectively. The *Playback Floats* keep track of how long the particle effect has been playing. The two *Custom Events* that the effect uses are fired off

when the particle effect fully completes (i.e. no more particles are left alive) and when a particle effect finishes emitting.

2.3.3 Life Cycle

2.3.3.1 Overview

The life cycle of a *Particle Effect Component* is very similar to the one that was developed by Reeves, and it can be described as 4 main phases:

1. Initialization
2. Update
3. Render
4. Clean Up

2.3.3.2 Initialization Phase

During the **Initialization** phase, the *Particle Effect Component* creates the *Drawable*, *Emitter*, *Concurrent Particle Data*, and, if specified by the *Particle Effect* instance, its *Affectors*. It also creates the *Particle Array* and initializes the *Bounding Shapes*.

2.3.3.3 Update Phase

The **Update** phase uses 4 states to characterize the current playback state of the particle effect, which are **Starting**, **Playing**, **Stopping**, and **Not Playing**. During the **Starting** state, particles are initialized to be inactive before it updates the particle effect for the first time and enters the **Playing** state. The **Playing** state is when particles are rendered and updated. If, during the **Playing** state, the particle effect may enter a **Stopping** state if the playback timer exceeds the effect's duration. However, it may go back to a **Playing** state if active particles still remain within the *Particle Array*. When the particle effect's duration time has elapsed and there are no more active particles, the particle effect finally enters the **Not Playing** state and the particle effect no longer does anything. The bulk of a particle

effect's time is spent during the **Playing** state, and that is the state of the **Update** phase that we will be focusing on throughout our study and will be discussing at length.

Code Listing 4: The struct that is used to bundle all information needed by the background task performing the particle update.

```

1  struct ParticleUpdateDesc final
2  {
3      ParticleEffectCSPtr m_particleEffect;
4      ParticleEmitterSPtr m_particleEmitter;
5      std::vector<ParticleAffectorSPtr> m_particleAffectors;
6      std::shared_ptr<dynamic_array<Particle>> m_particleArray;
7      ConcurrentParticleDataSPtr m_concurrentParticleData;
8      f32 m_playbackTime = 0.0f;
9      f32 m_deltaTime = 0.0f;
10     Vector3 m_entityPosition;
11     Vector3 m_entityScale;
12     Quaternion m_entityOrientation;
13     bool m_interpolateEmission = false;
14 };

```

When the particle effect is updating, it prepares a struct containing pertinent information to hand over to a background task. This struct contains pointers to the *Particle Effect*, *Emitter*, *Affector(s)*, *Particle Array*, *Concurrent Particle Data*. It additionally holds some other miscellaneous information, such as the effect's parent entity's position, scale, and orientation. The struct in its entirety is shown in Code Listing 4. After it prepares the struct, it uses the *Application Task Scheduler* application system to schedule a background task. This process is shown using pseudocode in lines 1 - 11 in Code Listing 5.

As mentioned before in Section 2.3.2, the **Particle Update Task** updates particles from the *Particle Array*, applies *Affectors* to the particles, emits particles using the *Emitter*, calculates its new *Bounding Shapes*, and it updates *Concurrent Particle Data* with the new information. Lines 13 - 41 demonstrate these actions in Code Listing 5.

Code Listing 5: Pseudocode describing how a *Particle Effect Component* is updated by scheduling a background task.

```

1 ParticleEffectComponent::OnUpdate()
2 {
3     // Get a struct containing copies (and pointers) to pass to the task
4     copiedAtts = CopyUpdateAttributes();
5
6     // Schedule a task to update the particle in the background
7     ApplicationTaskScheduler.ScheduleTask
8     ({
9         ParticleUpdateTask(copiedAtts);
10    });
11 }
12
13 ParticleUpdateTask(copiedAtts)
14 {
15     // Update particles if they are active
16     for(particle : copiedAtts.particleArray)
17     {
18         if(particle.isActive)
19         {
20             particle.UpdateValues();
21         }
22     }
23
24     // Apply affectors
25     for(affector : copiedAtts.particleAffectors)
26     {
27         affector.AffectParticles();
28     }
29
30     // Try to emit
31     newParticleIndicesArray = copiedAtts.particleEmitter.EmitParticles();
32
33     // Update bounding shapes
34     AABB, Sphere = CalculateBoundingShapes();
35
36     // Copy this updated data to the concurrent particle data object
37     copiedAtts.particleConcurrentParticleData.CommitParticleData
38         (particleArray,
39          newParticleIndicesArray,
40          AABB, Sphere);
41 }

```

Code Listing 6 illustrates how the function, **CommitParticleData**, copies data from the background task to the *Concurrent Particle Data* instance. The function first copies all of the particles in the *Particle Array*, and only a subset of information that is related to drawing particles is copied per particle. It then appends the indices of the particles that were just newly emitted to its member array, *newParticleIndices*. At the end, it copies the

Bounding Objects. During all of this, the *Concurrent Particle Data* instance is locked by locking a member variable mutex.

Code Listing 6: Pseudocode describing what **CommitParticleData** does when it copies its data to the *Concurrent Particle Data* instance.

```

1 ConcurrentParticleData::CommitParticleData (particleArray,
2                                           newParticleIndicesArray,
3                                           AABB, Sphere)
4 {
5     // Lock the mutex for the scope of the whole function
6     using lock (this.mutex)
7     {
8         // Copy over all particles to the member particle array
9         for (i = 0 to particleArray.size())
10            {
11                this.particleArray[i] = particleArray[i].copySubset();
12            }
13
14        // Append the new indices to the member new indices array
15        this.newParticleIndices.append( newParticleIndices.copy() );
16
17        // Copy the bounding information to the member variables
18        this.AABB = AABB.copy();
19        this.Sphere = Sphere.copy();
20    }
21 }

```

2.3.3.4 Render Phase

Unlike the **Update** phase, the **Render** phase is not directly called by the *Particle Effect Component*. Instead, it is called by the *Renderer* application system. The *Renderer* retrieves the active scene from the *State Manager*, filters entities added to the scene that have *Render Components*, and attempts to render them.

The **Render** function uses the *Drawable* instance to draw the *Particle Effect Component*. The *Drawable*, in turn, uses *Concurrent Particle Data* to read the information needed about the particle effect in order to render it. The **Draw** function within the *Drawable* first locks the *Concurrent Particle Data* instance using a **Lock** function, and then proceeds to work with the copied data in *Concurrent Particle Data*. It uses the *newParticleIndices* to register

newly emitted particles to the *Static Billboard* that is used for rendering, and continues on to iterate over the copied array of particles in order to draw each particle that is currently active. When it is finished, it unlocks the *Concurrent Particle Data* instance.

Code Listing 7: Pseudocode showing how a *Particle Effect Component* uses its *Drawable* to render itself.

```

1 ParticleEffectComponent::Render(camera)
2 {
3     // Use the Particle Drawable to draw particles to the screen
4     if(this.playbackState == playing or this.playbackState == stopping)
5     {
6         this.drawable->Draw(camera);
7     }
8 }
9
10 Drawable::Draw(camera)
11 {
12     // Lock the Concurrent Particle Data object
13     this.concurrentParticleData->Lock();
14
15     // Activate the newly emitted particles in the static billboard
16     for(int index : this.concurrentParticleData->GetNewParticleIndices())
17     {
18         ActivateParticleInBillboard(index);
19     }
20
21     // Iterate through all of the particles and draw each one
22     DrawParticles(this.concurrentParticleData->GetParticleArray(), camera);
23
24     // Unlock the Concurrent particle Data object
25     this.concurrentParticleData->Unlock();
26 }

```

2.3.3.5 Clean Up Phase

Of all phases, this is one is by far the simplest. It releases all resources and clears allocated arrays. Specifically, it cleans up the *Particle Array*, the *Concurrent Particle Data* instance, the *Drawable* instance, the *Emitter* instance, and the array of *Affectors*.

2.3.4 Usage

Creating a basic scene that uses a *Particle Effect Component* in ChilliSource is fairly simple. As Code Listing 8 illustrates, it requires that we first create a camera along with a light source and add them both to the current *State's Scene*. Although a state system, *Basic Entity Factory*, abstracts some of this code, Code Listing 9³ demonstrates that utilizing ChilliSource's API to create an entity like an ambient light is still easy to use and understand. We did not need to do this, but we also used the *Basic Entity Factory* to create a room in our scene.

Code Listing 8: Creating a scene that adds a basic *Particle Effect Component* in ChilliSource.

```

1  void State::OnInit()
2  {
3      // Retrieve the resource pool application system to create a particle effect
4      // Set the state's current scene's clear color to black
5      GetScene()->SetClearColor(CS::Colour::k_black);
6
7      // Retrieve a state system that will help create basic entities like
8      // cameras, rooms, and lights.
9      auto basicEntityFactory = CS::Application::Get()
10         ->GetSystem<Common::BasicEntityFactory>();
11
12     // Create a basic room and add it to the scene
13     CS::EntitySPtr room = basicEntityFactory->CreateRoom();
14     room->GetTransform().SetPosition(0.0f, 10.0f, 0.0f);
15     GetScene()->Add(room);
16
17     // Create a third person camera and add it to the scene
18     auto camera = basicEntityFactory
19         ->CreateThirdPersonCamera(room, CS::Vector3(0.0f, -9.0f, 0.0f));
20     GetScene()->Add(std::move(camera));
21
22     // Create an ambient light and add it to the scene
23     CS::EntitySPtr ambientLight = basicEntityFactory
24         ->CreateAmbientLight
25         (CS::Colour(0.65f, 0.65f, 0.65f, 1.0f));
26     GetScene()->Add(ambientLight);
27
28     // Create a particle effect entity and add it to the scene
29     auto particleEntity = CreateParticleEffect();
30     GetScene()->Add(std::move(particleEntity));
31 }

```

³This is the only time within this paper that we will not use pseudocode. Since we are demonstrating how to use and create a *Particle Effect Component*, it seemed appropriate to show the code verbatim.

Code Listing 9: The function to create an ambient light with the *Basic Entity Factory* state system.

```

1 CS::EntityUPtr BasicEntityFactory::CreateAmbientLight
2                                     (const CS::Colour& in_colour)
3 {
4     // Use the application system, Render Component Factory, to create an
5     // ambient light.
6     auto ambientLightComponent = m_renderComponentFactory
7                                     ->CreateAmbientLightComponent(in_colour);
8
9     // Create an entity, and attach the ambient light component to it.
10    auto entity = CS::Entity::Create();
11    entity->AddComponent(ambientLightComponent);
12
13    // Return the entity
14    return entity;
15 }

```

Once we've added a room, lighting, and a camera to our scene, we create a particle effect entity using a function called **CreateParticleEffect**. The exact code inside of this function is shown in Code Listing 10. Inside of this function, we use the main *Application* instance to generate a *Particle Effect* from a *csparticle* file, and it accomplishes this by using a *Resource Pool* application system. Once we have a *Particle Effect*, we can use a *Render Component Factory* application system to create a *Particle Effect Component* using that *Particle Effect*. Lastly, we must add the *Particle Effect Component* to an entity and add that entity to the current state's scene.

Code Listing 10: Creating a basic particle effect component with ChilliSource.

```

1 CS::EntityUPtr State::CreateParticleEffect()
2 {
3     // Retrieve the singleton application instance through a static method
4     auto app = CS::Application::Get();
5
6     // Retrieve the resource pool application system to create a particle effect
7     // from a JSON csparticle file
8     auto resourcePool = app->GetResourcePool();
9     auto particleEffect = resourcePool
10         ->LoadResource<CS::ParticleEffect>

```

```

11         (CS::StorageLocation::k_package,
12          "Particle/generic.csparticle");
13
14     // Using a render component factory application system and the particle
15     // effect, create a particle effect component
16     auto renderComponentFactory = app->GetSystem<CS::RenderComponentFactory>();
17     auto particleComponent = renderComponentFactory
18         ->CreateParticleEffectComponent(particleEffect);
19
20     // Set the particle component's playback to looping
21     particleComponent
22         ->SetPlaybackType(CS::ParticleEffectComponent::PlaybackType::k_looping);
23
24     // Create an entity, and add the particle component to the entity
25     auto particleEntity = CS::Entity::Create();
26     particleEntity->AddComponent(std::move(particleComponent));
27
28     return particleEntity;
29 }

```

Compared to Reeves' particle systems, we can observe here that a *Particle Effect Component* is not composed of a hierarchy of child *Particle Effect Components*. As mentioned in Section 2.2.2, however, *Entities* are made up of *Components* and child *Entities*. Thus, ChilliSource's architecture allows the developer to create parent and child *Particle Effect Components* by nesting *Entities*.

CHAPTER 3 THE CHILLISOURCE AUTOMATED PONG GAME

3.1 Overview

The ChilliSource Automated Pong Game [4] (i.e. CSAPong) is the application that we used to aid in our study of ChilliSource’s *Particle Effect Components*. CSAPong is a derivative of CSPong [5], a simple pong game created with ChilliSource that was developed by the ChilliWorks team. CSPong was built to illustrate as much of the engine as possible without creating a complex game, and the three main states attempt to reflect this goal. These states include the *Splash State*, the *Main Menu State*, and the *Game State*. These states help show the engine’s life cycle events, how to use the UI app system, how to make custom state systems, how to utilize custom events, how to use the *State Manager*, and, most importantly, how you can design entities and components to add enemy AI, player interaction, physics, collision detection, and so on. All three of these states are shown in Figure 3.1.

Unlike CSPong, CSAPong only uses a single state, the *Game State*. The main application instance restarts the *Game State* a number of times, and it automatically quits the application when it’s finished. CSAPong does not have enemy AI or player interaction (i.e. enemy and player paddles), but the left and right walls do collide with the wall and keep track of the ”score”. Additionally, CSAPong attaches a *Particle Effect Component* to the ball that will emit particles as the ball moves around the arena. Figure 3.2 shows a simple example of CSAPong in action.

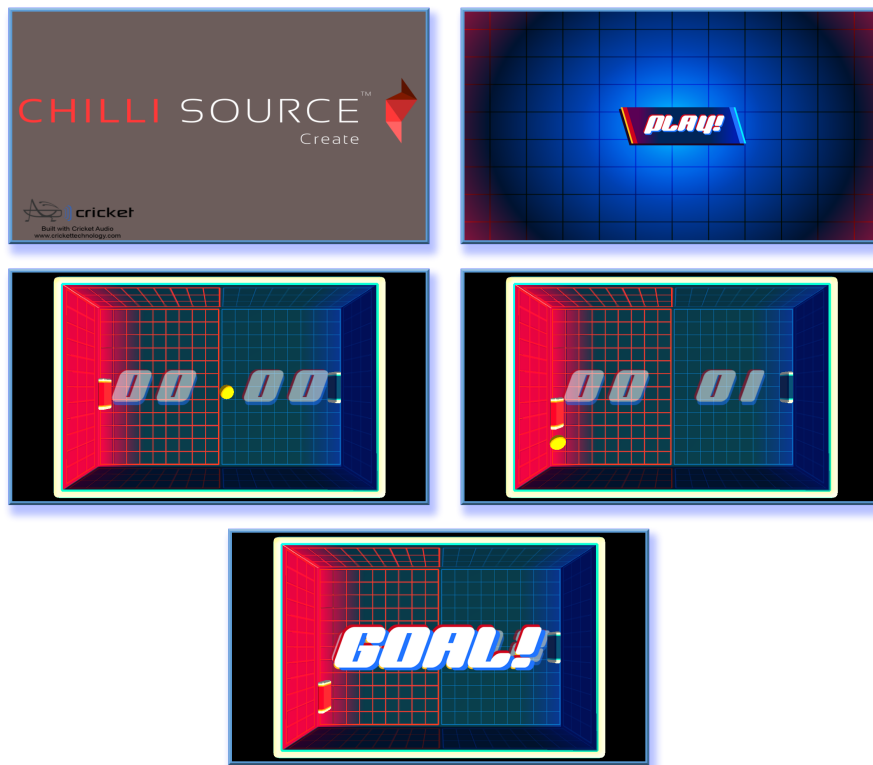


Figure 3.1: The above screenshots illustrate the original pong game. The screenshots were taken from the beginning of the application to the first goal. The top-left screenshot is from the *Splash State*, the top-right screenshot is from the *Main Menu State*, and the other three screenshots are from the *Game State*.

3.2 Architecture

3.2.1 Overview

Although it is not necessary to go over every single class that makes up CSAPong, it is essential to understand the general architecture of it. As shown in Figure 3.3, we can broadly describe the structure having two main parts, the ChilliSource engine¹ and the CSAPong application itself. Further, CSAPong can be defined as having *Application Systems*, a *Game State*, and the *Game State's State Systems*.

¹Obviously, we know that the entirety of the ChilliSource engine is part of the CSAPong application, but we will include it in our discussion of CSAPong's architecture due to the custom application systems that we created within ChilliSource specifically for CSAPong.

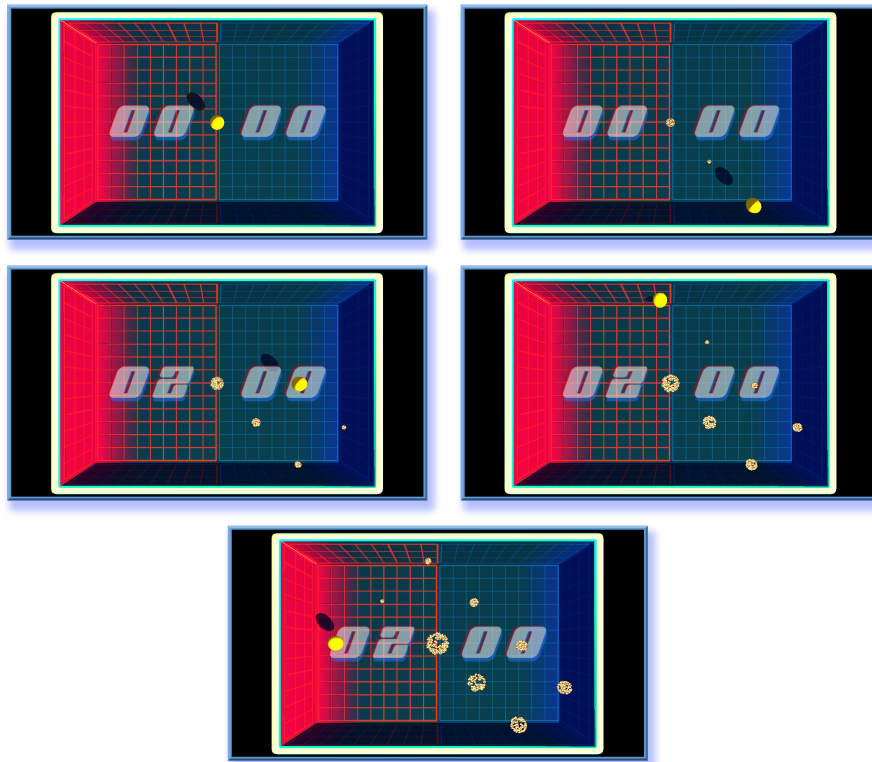


Figure 3.2: The above screenshots illustrate the automated pong game. The screenshots were taken 1 second apart with the ball starting at the beginning of the arena. Due to a small bug, note that the score increments by 2 when the ball collides with the opposing "team's" wall.

3.2.2 CSAPong Application

The *CSAPong Application* instance creates all application systems that will have a lifetime that lasts throughout the whole application. This includes *Particle Effect Component Factory* and *Profiling* application systems, where the former is defined within CSAPong and the latter is defined within ChilliSource itself. It also handles pushing the initial *Game State*, restarting the *Game State*, and quitting the application.

3.2.3 Application Systems

Although not explicitly part of CSAPong, the *Profiling Application Systems* are integral to our studies. They are custom-made application systems that help keep track of engine-

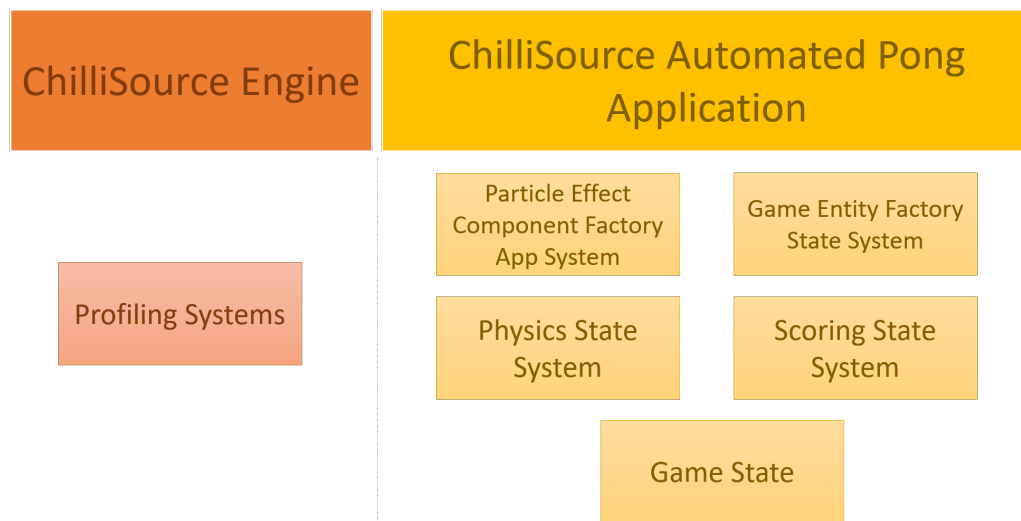


Figure 3.3: The basic architecture of the automated pong game.

specific metrics such as particles per emission, particles actually emitted, particles actually rendered, time spent in **ParticleUpdateTask**, time spent in **CommitParticleData**, and so forth. The *Profiling Application Systems* will be discussed more in detail in Chapter 4.

The *Particle Effect Component Factory Application System* generate *Particle Effect Components* and attach them to entities. It allows the user to hand it an entity, a csparticle file path, the number of desired *Particle Effect Component(s)* to add, and it will add the desired *Particle Effect Component(s)* to the entity. This application system is used to generate different kinds of particle effects as CSAPong runs.

3.2.4 Game State

The *Game State* manages the game’s life cycle, its entities and components, and its user interface. Similar to the main application instance, the *Game State* creates all state systems that will have the same lifetime as the state. It uses the *Game Entity Factory State System* on initialization to create a camera, some lighting, the arena, and the ball. The *Game Entity Factory*, in turn, uses the *Particle Effect Component Factory* to attach particle effects to the ball during that ball’s creation. It also signals the *Profiling Application Systems* to start

gathering metrics once the *Game State* is fully initialized and has started the game.

3.2.5 State Systems

The *Physics State System* handles the movement of dynamic bodies (such as the ball) and collision checking. Being that ChilliSource is a composition-based system, this behavior is described with components that are attached to entities. Thus, if we want the ball to be able to move, we attach a special type of component to the ball, a *Dynamic Body Component*, that is used by the *Physics State System*. Additionally, if we want collisions to occur between dynamic bodies and the walls, we must add static body components to the four wall entities within the arena.

The *Scoring State System* uses the collision detection in the *Physics State System* to trigger points being added to each "opposing team". As we can see in Figure 3.3, however, there is a small bug in which 2 points are awarded each time the ball collides with the wall. The bug did not interfere with our study of the *Particle Effect Component*, and so time was not taken to fix it.

3.3 Gameplay

3.3.1 Logistics

The gameplay can be described as a series of "games" where the ball appears begins at the center of the arena, accelerates toward the bottom right corner, bounces to the right-most wall, bounces to the center of the top wall, and heads toward the center of the left-most wall. Although the game can continue for longer than this, the majority of our studies set the "game length", or *run time*, to 5 seconds, and so this is the behavior that we saw the most often. This ball movement was specifically chosen to minimize the number of particles that would overlap each other during a game so we could challenge the system to render as many particles as it could. If the particles did overlap, then those particles would be culled, or not drawn, and thus the engine would not be working as hard.

Another variable that we can change is the number of "games", or the *maximum run number*, that will be "played". The game has the ability to change particle effect types during execution, and so the maximum run number is the number of games that are ran *for each* particle effect type that we want to use. For example, if we had 3 different particle effect types and the maximum run number was set to 3, then we would expect to see 9 games play in total.

When the "game" is over, the *CSAPong Application* instance destroys the current *Game State* and creates a new *Game State* with the same kind of particle effect type until the maximum run number is reached. The application will then either create a new *Game State* with the next particle effect type or it will quit the application if there is not another particle effect type to "play". A series of files within a timestamped folder will be placed in the application's save data once the application has finally quit. These files contain the instrumentation information, and we will learn more about them in Chapter 4.

3.3.2 Examples

Particle effects, as we found in the previous chapter, are considerably complicated and have many variables that can be changed. Although we changed many of these variables during our studies, we can generalize the different scenarios we encountered as the following:

- No particles emitting during the game
- A single, giant burst of particles emitting during the game
- A steady stream of particle emissions during the game

The following figures show screenshots of these three different scenarios.

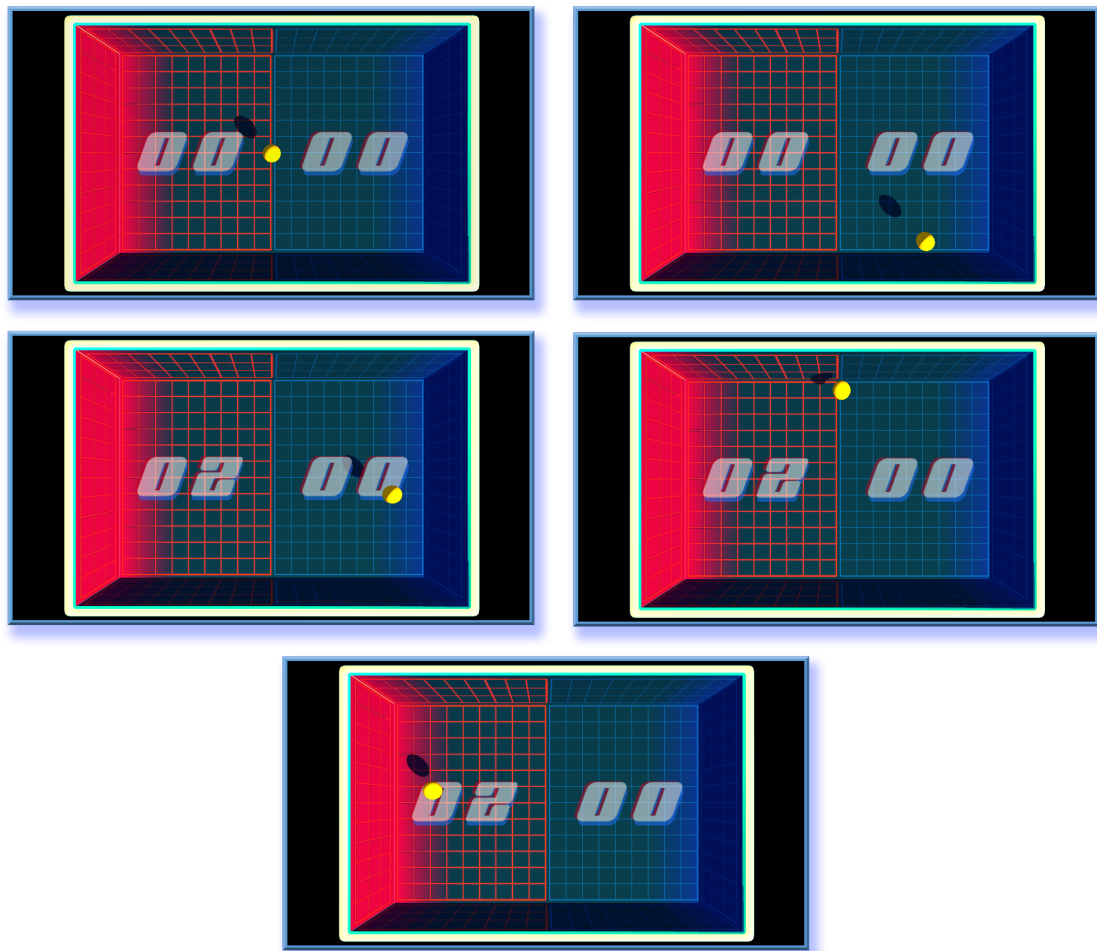


Figure 3.4: A series of screenshots showing the automated game with no particles. The screenshots were taken 1 second apart with the ball starting at the beginning of the arena.

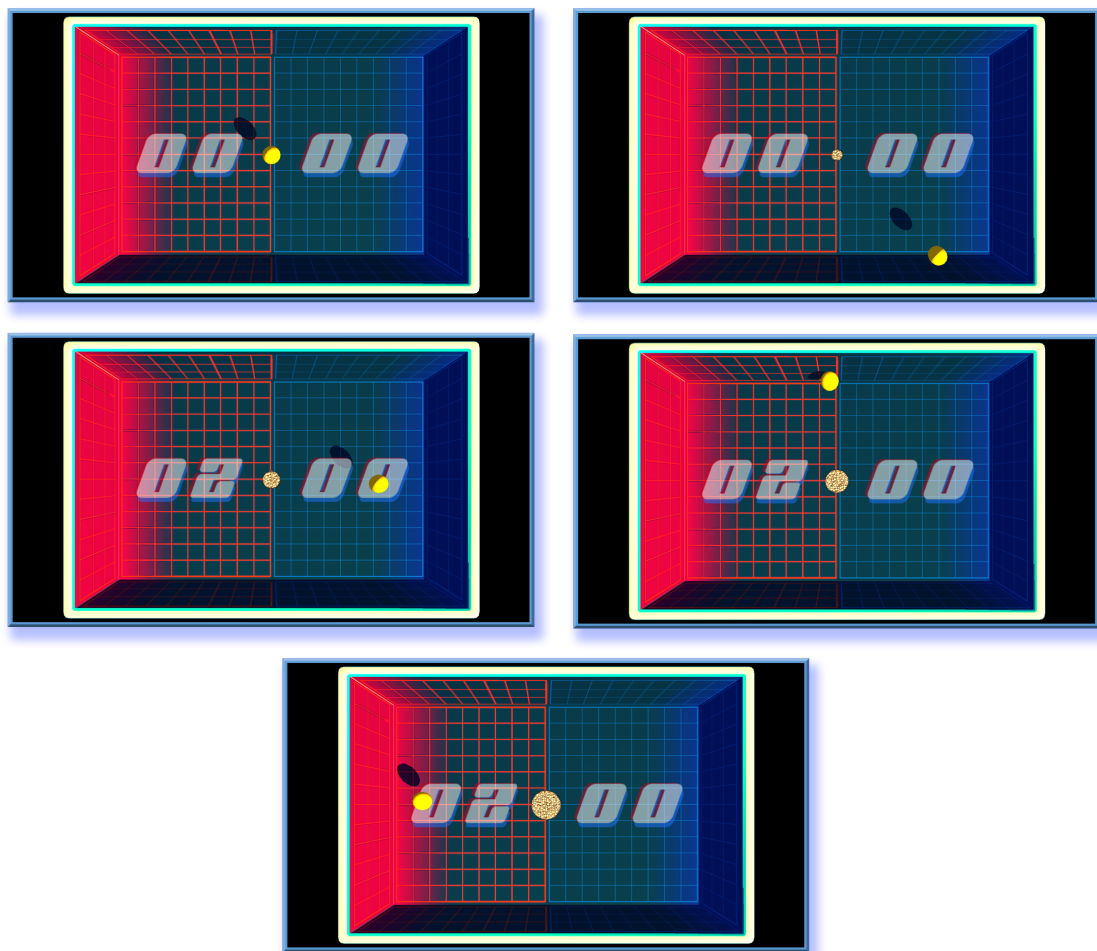


Figure 3.5: A series of screenshots showing the automated game with a single, giant burst of particles. The screenshots were taken 1 second apart with the ball starting at the beginning of the arena.

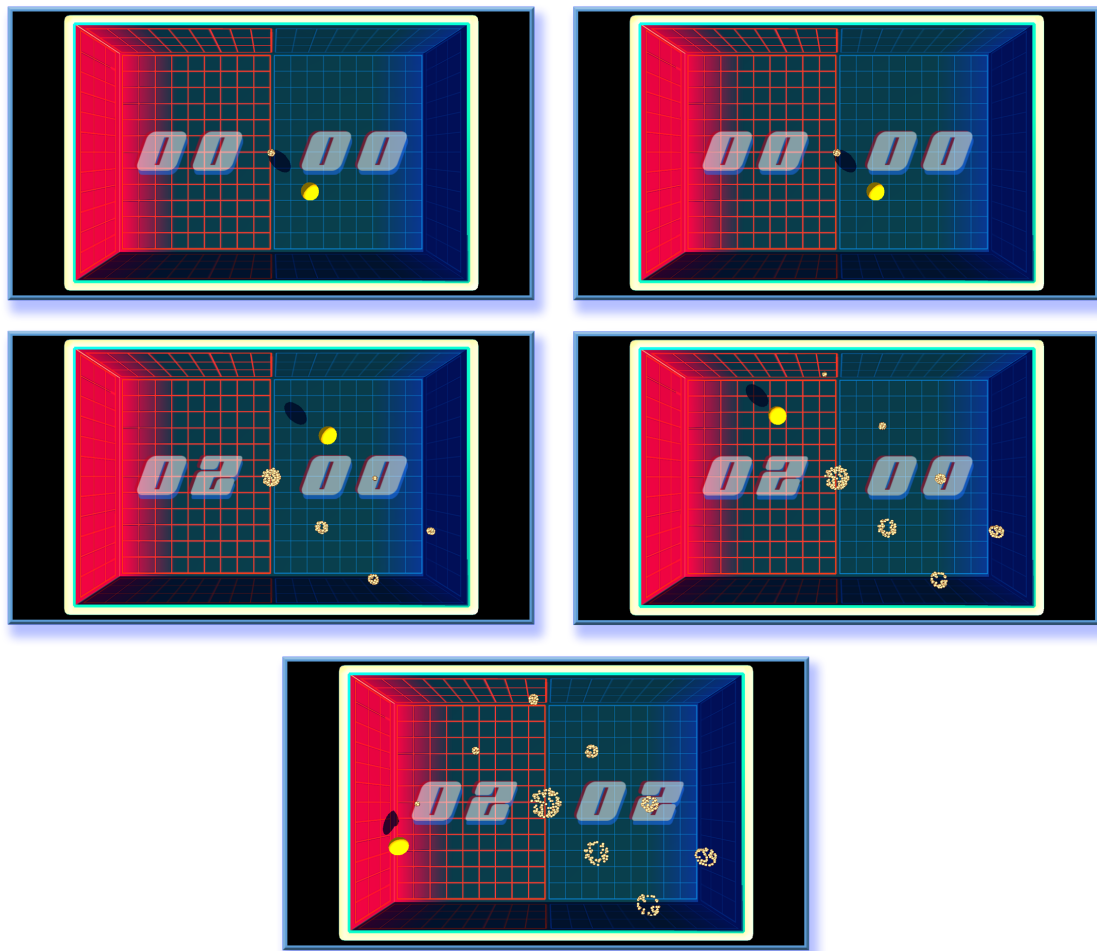


Figure 3.6: A series of screenshots showing the automated game with a steady stream of particle emissions. The screenshots were taken 1 second apart with the ball starting at the beginning of the arena.

CHAPTER 4 INSTRUMENTATION

4.1 Overview

In order to numerically quantify what occurs during games that are ran by CSAPong, we instrumented different parts of the engine. We examined various metrics (e.g. particles actually emitted), and we also timed how long various sections of code took to run. These two use cases were separated into two application systems that resided within the engine itself, the *Metrics* and *Timing* systems. As mentioned before, these systems will save a series of files of the gathered information that will go into a timestamped folder within CSAPong's save data file system. These files fueled the direction of our studies due to their ability to answer questions about the engine, e.g. what function in *Particle Effect Component* takes the longest to run?

4.2 Metrics System

4.2.1 Metadata

Although not structurally complicated, the *Metrics System* keeps track of a great deal of primitives that describe the series of games ran by CSAPong. The following is a list of the tracked primitives that remained constant throughout the games:

- ***Are particles looping***
 - Whether or not the particle effect component is looping. This means that the particle effect will continue even after the duration has elapsed.
- ***Number of particle effects***
 - The number of particle effect components that were attached to the ball entity.

attribute	value
are particles looping	TRUE
num particle effects	1
min particles	500
max particles	2000
particles step	500
is total max particles changing	TRUE
is particles per emission changing	TRUE
particles per emission	0
total maximum particles	0
particles per emission step	50
total maximum particles step	500
total num runs	2
duration per run	5

Figure 4.2 An example of metadata output by the *Metrics System*.

CSAPong Game Num	Particles Per Emission	Total Maximum Particles	Particles
1	50	500	500
2	100	1000	1000
3	150	1500	1500
4	200	2000	2000

Figure 4.3 An example of the changing particle values during games in CSAPong.

- ***Is total maximum particles changing***
 - Whether or not *total maximum particles* is changing across different particle effect types.
- ***Total maximum particles***
 - If *is total maximum particles changing* is false, then this will be the constant value of *total maximum particles* across particle effect types.
- ***Is particles per emission changing***
 - Whether or not *particles per emission* is changing across different particle effect types.
- ***Particles per emission***
 - If *is particles per emission changing* is false, then this will be the constant value of *particles per emission* across particle effect types.
- ***Minimum particles***
 - The minimum value for the changing values (i.e. *total maximum particles* and/or *particles per emission*).
- ***Maximum particles***
 - The maximum value for the changing values (i.e. *total maximum particles* and/or *particles per emission*).
- ***Particles step***

- The step value for the changing values (i.e. *total maximum particles* and/or *particles per emission*). This is used in conjunction with the minimum and maximum particles values to determine how many particle effects to create and use during CSAPong’s execution.
- ***Particles per emission step***
 - If *is particles per emission changing* is true, then this will dictate the step value for *particles per emission* across particle effect types. This is generally a fraction of *particles step*.
- ***Total maximum particles step***
 - If *is total maximum particles changing* is true, then this will dictate the step value for *total maximum particles* across particle effect types. This is generally a fraction of *particles step*.
- ***Total number of runs***
 - The number of games to run per particle effect type.
- ***Duration per run***
 - The amount of time in seconds that a single game lasts.

Let us examine Figure 4.2 in order to make the distinction clear between the different kinds of particle variables. The *minimum particles* is 500, the *maximum particles* is 2000, and the *particles step* is 500. Thus, this tells us right away that there will be $2000/500 = 4$ kinds of particle effects that will be created and played¹. This will be true regardless of the other variables’ values. From the figure, we know that *particles per emission* and *total maximum particles* are changing across particle effects and they will not be constant values. Thus, their ”step” values will tell us how much each variable will be added to as we advance through the 4 different kinds of particle effects. We can see that the *total maximum particles step* is 500, or 100% of the *particles step*. Additionally, we can see that the *particles per emission step* is 50, or 10% of the *particles step*. Figure 4.3 shows how all of these particle variables change as CSAPong executes. We should note that, since we have 4 different kinds of particle effects and 2 *total number of runs*, CSAPong would play a total of $4 \times 2 = 8$ times in this example.

¹Note that we do not subtract 500 from 2000 since the range is inclusive.

4.2.2 Metrics

The metrics data contain three engine metrics, but it also contains six other system metrics. Engine metrics are metrics that originate from the engine, e.g. counting the number of times that each particle was drawn. System metrics are metrics that come from the metrics system, e.g. the current game run number. The following list shows all of the different engine and system metrics that are tracked:

- *Engine Metrics*
 - *All effects particles actually emitted*
 - * This retrieves the size of the *New Particle Indices* array after each emission and adds it to this metric.
 - *All effects particles actually rendered*
 - * This is incremented every time a particle is rendered in the *Drawable* instance.
 - *Render ball called*
 - * This is incremented every time the ball is rendered.
- *System Metrics*
 - *Run number*
 - *Per effect total max particles*
 - *Per effect particles per emission*
 - *All effects total max particles*
 - *All effects particles per emission*

run num	per effect total max particles	per effect particles per emission	all effects total max particles	all effects particles per emission	all effects particles actually emitted	all effects particles actually rendered	render ball called
0	500	50	500	50	500	49250	340
1	500	50	500	50	500	34250	302
0	1000	100	1000	100	1000	69400	300
1	1000	100	1000	100	1000	68500	302
0	1500	150	1500	150	1500	102300	300
1	1500	150	1500	150	1500	101700	302
0	2000	200	2000	200	2000	135600	300
1	2000	200	2000	200	2000	135000	302

Figure 4.4: An example of metrics output by the *Metrics System*.

4.2.3 Particle Effect Definition

```
$ python generate_particles.py -h
usage: generate_particles.py [-h] -changing {PPE,TMP,Both} [-min MIN]
                             [-max MAX] [-step STEP] [-constant CONSTANT]
                             [-tmpStep TMPSTEP] [-ppeStep PPESTEP] [-dir DIR]

Generate Particle JSON Files

optional arguments:
  -h, --help            show this help message and exit
  -changing {PPE,TMP,Both}
                        Either the particles per emission (PPE) or total max
                        particles (TMP) will be changing from min to max.
  -min MIN              The minimum particles- either PPE or TMP. (non-
                        negative number, default: 0)
  -max MAX              The maximum particles- either PPE or TMP. (non-
                        negative number, default: 1000)
  -step STEP            The step between min and max particles- either PPE or
                        TMP. (default: 100)
  -constant CONSTANT    The constant number of particles, either PPE or TMP
                        but it will be opposite of arg "changing". If both are
                        changing, then this has no effect. (default: 10000)
  -tmpStep TMPSTEP      The percent that TMP will step by if it is changing.
                        (default: 1.0)
  -ppeStep PPESTEP      The percent that PPE will step by if it is changing.
                        (default: 1.0)
  -dir DIR              The output directory name (default is "Generated" and
                        it will create it for you)
```

Figure 4.5: Shows the parameters that the generate particles script can use.

As we mentioned in Chapter 2, *Particle Effects* that are passed into *Particle Effect Components* cannot be created programmatically. They must be created with JSON particle definition files. If we wanted to create tens or hundreds of particle effects to test in CSAPong, then we would have to make just as many JSON particle definition files. This is clearly something that we do not want to do by hand, and it instead should be automated. A script, **generate_particles.py**, was created to do just that. An example invocation of this script is shown in Code Listing 11, and that invocation will generate the particle definition files shown in Figure 4.6. Note that these particle effects are the same ones that were used in Figure 4.2.

Code Listing 11: An example invocation of the generate particles script.

```
1 | python generate_particles.py
2 | > -changing Both
3 | > -min 500 -max 2000 -step 500
4 | > -tmpStep 1.0 -ppeStep 0.1;
```

Name	Date modified	Type	Size
 500_particles.csparticle	11/2/2016 9:39 PM	CSPARTICLE File	2 KB
 1000_particles.csparticle	11/2/2016 9:39 PM	CSPARTICLE File	2 KB
 1500_particles.csparticle	11/2/2016 9:39 PM	CSPARTICLE File	2 KB
 2000_particles.csparticle	11/2/2016 9:39 PM	CSPARTICLE File	2 KB

Figure 4.6: Shows the particle files that were generated by an invocation like in Code Listing 11.

4.3 Timing System

4.3.1 Visual Studio

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4.3.2 Shiny

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4.3.3 Custom Timing

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4.4 Output

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4.5 Initial Results

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CHAPTER 5 CHILLISOURCE PARTICLE EFFECT COMPONENT CASE STUDIES

5.1 Overview

5.2 Using More Than One Mutex

5.2.1 Code

5.2.2 Discussion

5.2.3 Results

5.3 Using A Lock Free Data Structure

5.3.1 Code

5.3.2 Discussion

5.3.3 Results

CHAPTER 6 CHILLISOURCE PARTICLE EFFECT COMPONENT OBSERVATIONS

6.1 Using Copies to Reduce Contention

6.1.1 Overview

6.1.2 Using the Concurrent Particle Data Object

6.1.3 Not Using the Concurrent Particle Data Object

6.1.4 Comparison

6.2 Multithreading and Task Scheduling

6.2.1 Overview

6.2.2 The ChilliSource Task Scheduler

6.2.3 Using the Small Task

6.2.4 Using the GameLogic Task

6.2.5 Using No Background Task

6.2.6 Comparison

6.3 Taxing the Engine and Emission Failure

6.3.1 Overview

6.3.2 Emission Failure

6.3.3 Emission Failure Source

6.3.4 Emission Failure Solution

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